Return to Moabit

‘The landing at Tegel was good,’ Honecker marvelled, after the Tu-134 touched down and taxied to a remote freight area. ‘People were standing on the roadside; I saw banners, red flags. I heard calls from friends and foes. The kind words predominated.’ The mood quickly changed when he sped toward Moabit prison to jeers of ‘Murderer!’ from a noisy crowd of onlookers stationed at the prison gates. The media hysteria resembled the ‘reporting of a large sporting event … especially the landing of the plane with Honecker on board and the prisoner’s journey through Berlin,’ according to Friedrich Wolff.

‘After fifty-seven years, I could see Moabit from the inside again,’ Honecker recounted, as his eyes roamed over the prison. ‘At Christmas 1935, the Gestapo brought me here from their headquarters on Prinz-Albrecht-Straße. I was in custody here for a year and a half. For how long will it be this time?’ he mused. After a preliminary lecture – which was orderly and polite – the new inmate was given the prison number 244/92 and informed he would appear in court the following morning and, after a brief check-up, was pronounced fit for jail.

His arrival in Berlin was the subject of furious commentary in the media. Neue Zeit– a one-time GDR daily still in circulation – took up the assault. Noting the political climate was now starkly different, it reminded readers that the former General Secretary, like no other, stood for the collapse of the GDR and the ‘vain, senile old men’ of the SED leadership. ‘His name is associated with the unbearable restriction of freedoms. And yet there remains a contradiction: Honecker was one of too few Germans who actively resisted Hitler.’1 While observing that youngsters were ‘more interested in the return of Batman to the screen than the return of Erich,’ Neue Zeit conceded interest did not give way to indifference. ‘On the contrary,’ it asserted, ‘the less one hears about the hiccups between Bonn-Santiago-Moscow, the more popular anger rises against this old man, incapable of all insight.’2 Somewhat facetiously, Neue Zeit suggested it